

G question formation

V figuring out meaning from context

P intonation: showing interest

1 READING & SPEAKING

a Look at the photos of Simone Biles and Dan Stevens and read their biographical info. Have you watched any of her competitions, or seen any of his TV shows or movies? What did you think of them?

b Now read the interviews and complete the questions.

c Read the interviews again and focus on their answers. Write **S** (Simone) or **D** (Dan). Which question(s) helped you answer **S** or **D**?

Who do you think...?

- 1 ☐ doesn't eat any animal products
- 2 ☐ doesn't have a partner right now
- 3 ☐ is currently living in California
- 4 ☐ doesn't like insects
- 5 ☐ is romantic
- 6 ☐ is very family-oriented
- 7 ☐ becomes emotional when they're tired
- 8 ☐ likes to make the last point in a discussion

d Which of the questions in the interviews do you think are...?

- the most interesting
- the least interesting
- too personal to ask a person if you don't know them well

e Choose six questions from Q&A to ask your partner.

 Politely refusing to answer a question

If you are asked a question you think is inappropriate, or simply don't want to answer, you can say, *I'd prefer not to answer that* or *I'd rather not answer that if you don't mind*.

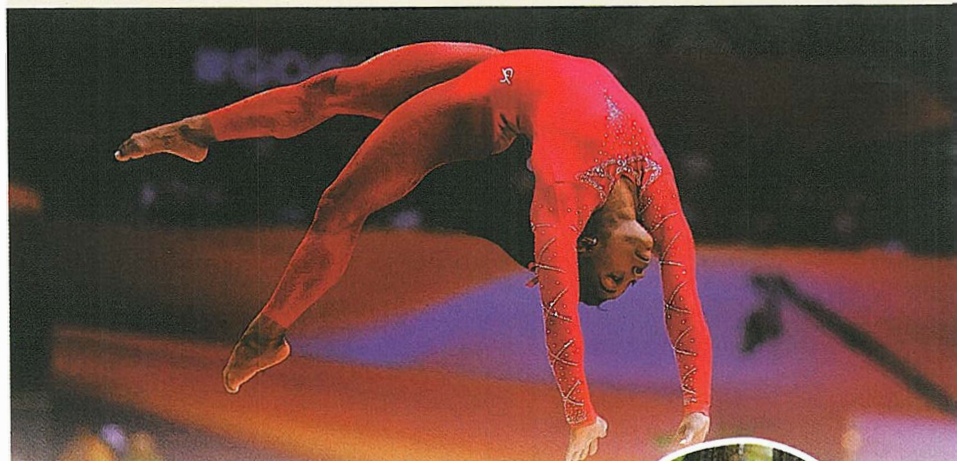
Glossary

decorated (adj.) given a medal as a sign of respect

podium (noun) a small platform that a person stands on to give a speech or receive a medal

Q&A

Every week the newspaper *The Guardian* chooses people who have been in the news recently, and publishes a short interview with them called **Q&A**.



Simone Biles is a gymnast who was born in the state of Ohio in 1997.

Biles has competed at the World Championships since 2013, and is now the most decorated gymnast in World Championship history. She has also won gold in the Olympic Games, and written an autobiography called *Courage to Soar*.



1 _____'s your most treasured possession?

My Olympic medals.

2 **What** _____ you want to be when you were growing up?

A nurse.

3 **What** _____ you like about yourself?

I like to have the last word.

4 **What** _____ your most embarrassing moment?

I was on the podium at the 2014 World Championships in China when a bee appeared out of nowhere and took a liking to my flowers.

5 **What** or _____ is the greatest love of your life?

Food.

6 **What** _____ your superpower be?

To be a witch. A good witch, of course. It would be cool to control things with my mind and do spells.

7 _____ did you last cry, and why?

Just a few days ago. I was overtired.

8 _____ would you like to be remembered?

As a confident, inspirational, and very bubbly person.

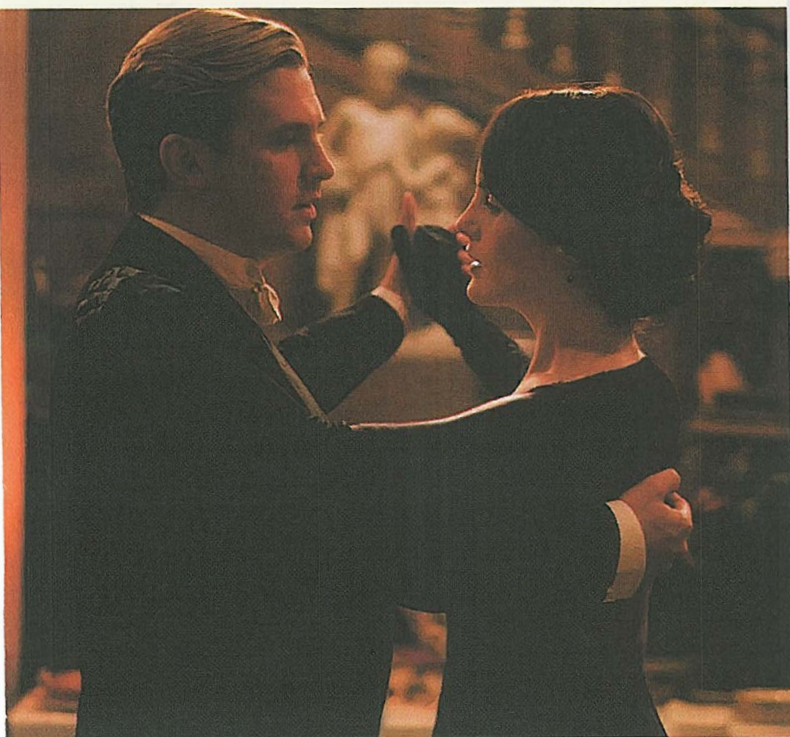
9 _____ word or phrase do you most overuse?

"Oh my gosh."

Dan Stevens, the actor, was born in England in 1982. He played Matthew Crawley on the TV show *Downton Abbey*, until his character died suddenly in a special Christmas episode. He has since starred in many successful TV shows and movies, including *Beauty and the Beast*, *Legion*, and *The Call of the Wild*.



- 1 _____ were you happiest?
My wedding day, eight years ago.
- 2 What _____ you owe your parents?
A lot – and probably quite a lot of money.
- 3 _____'s your wallpaper?
A photo of my kids, Willow, Aubrey, and Eden, who are eight, five, and one.
- 4 _____ keeps you awake at night?
My three kids.
- 5 _____ would you most like to say sorry to?
To *Downton Abbey* fans, for ruining their Christmas one year.
- 6 What single thing _____ improve the quality of your life?
One of those robot vacuum cleaners.
- 7 _____ do you relax?
I go for walks in Griffith Park, in L.A.
- 8 What _____ love feel like?
As if somebody's painted the world a different color.
- 9 _____ you have a "guilty pleasure"?
Yes, vegan cheesecake.



2 GRAMMAR question formation

- a **1.2** Listen to some journalists interviewing a famous actress who has just arrived in Toronto. Write down the four questions they ask.
- b Answer the questions below with a partner.
Which question is an example of...?
 - a question that ends with a preposition
 - a subject question, where there is no auxiliary verb
 - a question that uses a negative auxiliary verb
 - an indirect question
- c **G p.132 Grammar Bank 1A**
- d **G Communication Indirect questions A p.106 B p.110** Ask and answer indirect questions.

3 PRONUNCIATION intonation: showing interest

- 1.5** Listen to some people asking questions 1–5. Who sounds more interested each time, **a** or **b**?
 - 1 Do you have a big family?
 - 2 What don't you like about the place where you live?
 - 3 What sports or games are you good at?
 - 4 Do you think you have a healthy diet?
 - 5 What makes you feel happy?
- 1.6** Listen and repeat the questions with interested intonation.

Reacting to what someone says

When you ask someone a question and they answer, it is normal to show interest or sympathy. You can use:

- expressions such as *Oh, really? I'm sorry. What a shame!*
- exclamations such as *Wow! Me too! How interesting!*
- follow-up questions such as *Why (not)? Why is that? Why do you say that?*

- c **1.7** Now listen to five conversations using the questions in **a**. Complete the expressions or questions that the people use to react to the answers.
 - 1 Wow! That's a huge family.
 - 2 _____? What's wrong with them?
 - 3 _____! We could play a game one day.
 - 4 _____! How long have you been a vegan?
 - 5 _____? I can't think of anything worse!
- d **1.8** Listen and repeat the responses. Copy the intonation.
- e Ask and answer the questions in **a** with a partner. Use interested intonation, and react to your partner's answers.

4 READING & VOCABULARY figuring out meaning from context

- a Look at the cartoon. How do you think the candidate is feeling? How would you react if it happened to you?
- b Read the title of the article and the first paragraph. Then look at interview questions A–G. With a partner, say how you would answer them. Which question would you least like to be asked?
- A What do you usually do after a bad day at work?
B What's your biggest weakness?
C How would your enemy describe you?
D You have 50 red and 50 blue balls. How could you divide these between two containers to give the maximum probability of picking one of the colors?
E What's the most selfish thing you've ever done?
F Are you a nice person?
G What on your résumé is the closest thing to a lie?

Would YOU get the job?

Interviews are a source of anxiety for most **job-seekers**. Job website Glassdoor has created a list of some of the toughest interview questions from the elite companies where they were asked, and offers an expert opinion on the best possible answers.

1 ____ (The Phoenix Partnership)

How to answer: If you answer “nothing,” then you may look too defensive, as if you are hiding something, even if you are innocent. The best tactic would be to reply that everyone presents the best side of themselves on a résumé – that is the **point** of the document – but that you think lying, and even exaggeration, is wrong.

2 ____ (Condé Nast)

How to answer: You could just tell the interviewer that you are not the sort of person to make enemies, but that sometimes you've enjoyed a **good-natured rivalry** with someone, for example, in a sport. This will show your competitive side and your drive to succeed.

3 ____ (Page Group)

How to answer: This is an occasion when you could give a **light-hearted response**. Something like, “I don't consider myself to be selfish, but I always make sure I have some time during the week for myself, so I can practice art / tennis / soccer / singing.”

4 ____ (Palantir Technologies)

How to answer: Everyone should be prepared to answer this question, whatever job you're interviewing for. There's no **foolproof** answer – it's a good idea to have thought about a list of areas that are not your biggest strengths, but that wouldn't affect the role that you are interviewing for.



5 ____ (Clearwater Analytics)

How to answer: If you are a serious **math geek**, then you might have a decent chance of answering this one. One answer would be to put a single red ball in one container and all of the other balls in the other container.

6 ____ (Switch Consulting)

How to answer: Don't be afraid to talk about what you do to relax, and show how you have a healthy **work-life balance**. It's also a chance to say something about your personal life, which could be very helpful for making a good impression. For example, you could mention how you go to the gym to relax.

7 ____ (Badoo)

How to answer: Don't just answer “yes” or “no.” Think about your personality type and the culture of the company where you are interviewing. What is your **gut feeling** about the type of people that do well at the company? This should help you to give an appropriate answer.

- c Read the article once and complete it with questions A–G. Would you now feel more confident about answering the questions?

 Guessing the meaning of new words and phrases

When you are reading, you will often find a word or phrase you don't know. If it isn't possible to check the meaning in a dictionary, think about:

- the context (i.e., the other words around it).
- what part of speech the individual words are (e.g., a verb, an adjective, etc.).
- whether it's similar to another English word you know.
- whether it's similar to a word in your language.

If you still can't figure out what the word or phrase means, ignore it and continue reading.

- d Read the article again. With a partner, try to figure out what the **highlighted** words and phrases mean, and how you think they are pronounced. What helped you to figure them out?

- e Now match the **highlighted** words and phrases to 1–8.

- _____ (noun) a reaction based on feelings and emotions rather than thought and reason
- _____ (adj.) designed so that it cannot fail
- _____ (phrase) an answer that is intended to be amusing rather than serious
- _____ (noun, informal) a person who is very interested in and who knows a lot about a particular subject
- _____ (phrase) the number of hours per week you spend working compared with the number of hours you spend with your family, relaxing, etc.
- _____ (phrase) the main reason for something
- _____ (phrase) friendly competition
- _____ (noun) people who are looking for a job

- f Look at some more genuine interview questions. What do you think they would tell you about the candidate? Why? Do you think these kinds of questions really help interviewers to choose the best person for the job?

- What would you do if you were the one survivor of a plane crash? (Airbnb)
- Who do you think would win in a fight between Spider-Man and Batman? (Stanford University)
- What did you have for breakfast? (Banana Republic)
- Describe the color yellow to somebody who's blind. (Spirit Airlines)
- How many people flew out of Chicago last year? (Redbox software)
- What am I thinking right now? (TES Global)
- Who is your hero, and why? (General Electrics)
- Tell me something about your childhood. (Next)

- g Choose two questions in f to ask a partner.

5 LISTENING

- a Have you ever had an interview for a job or acceptance into a school? What kinds of questions did they ask you? Did you get the job or the acceptance?
- b  1.9 Listen to four people talking about a strange question they were asked in an interview. Complete questions 1–4.

What strange question were they asked?	How did they answer?	What happened in the end?
1 If you could _____ with _____ from the past, who would you choose and why?		
2 Do you _____ a _____? Are you planning to _____?		
3 Do you still _____?		
4 _____ would you like to be reincarnated as?		

- c Listen again and make notes in the rest of the chart.
- d Which of the questions do you think were acceptable to ask at an interview?

6 SPEAKING

- a  **Communication** Tough questions **A p.106 B p.110** Ask your partner some difficult interview questions.
- b Invent a tough interview question of your own, which you think might tell you something interesting about another person.
- c Ask your question to as many other students as possible and answer theirs.
- d Which questions did you think were the most interesting? Why?